# What the Apostle Paul Says About

# Marriage & Separation

## Based on the Greek New Testament

By Ernest R. Campbell

# *MARRIAGE*
# *&*
# *SEPARATION*

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CANYONVIEW PRESS

Silverton, OR 97381-9535

Unlocking Truth from the Greek New Testament

MARRIAGE & SEPARATION

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are translated by the author from the
United Bible Societies Greek Text
while considering the Majority Text
in passages of variance

Printed in the United States of America

# *About the Author*

Ernest R. Campbell was born at Michigan, North Dakota in 1915. His farm environment instilled in him the importance of *hard work*, gave a breadth of *experience*, and encouraged independent thinking and *initiative*. He moved to Oregon in 1933. For four years he worked in the electrical and radio broadcasting fields.

He received his B. A. degree from the University of Oregon. His major was in English literature, which has strengthened his ability in Biblical interpretation. His B. A. also included a major (hours beyond B. A.) in psychology and two years of classical Greek. He earned his B. D. and Th. D. degrees from Northern Baptist Theological Seminary. His major in Greek New Testament was under the renowned Greek scholar, Dr. Julius R. Mantey.

He has taught New Testament Greek at North Park College. He was Dean of the faculty at the Detroit Bible Institute where he taught beginner through advanced New Testament Greek. He has been a pastor with the Salem Bible Church for more than thirty years during which time his ministry has been based entirely on the Greek New Testament. Simultaneous with this he taught private Greek classes prior to the beginning of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary.

The author was one of the founders of an evening school in 1973, which became the forerunner of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary. At this time he introduced a new natural method of teaching New Testament Greek, which is now enabling Canyonview students to teach directly from their Greek New Testaments.

As the President of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary the author's *supreme burden* is to equip students to *literally teach the Books of the Bible in a verse by verse manner*. He is convinced that the ability to teach from the Greek New Testament is the *most important single factor* in accomplishing this end in an interesting and authoritative manner.

The author realistically recognizes that it is not possible for all Bible teachers to acquire competency in New Testament Greek. This is why he is in the process of writing *commentaries on Paul's Epistles*, that the English reader may more fully share in the treasures of the Greek text!

# *Introduction*

The purpose of this book is to exegete what the Apostle Paul has written on the subject of marriage and separation. We will exhaustively exegete First Corinthians 7:1-40; however, other passages which relate to the subject will be briefly gleaned for the pertinent truth in them. Our translation and exegesis are entirely based on the Greek text. We will deal with these passages in the order in which they appear in the New Testament.

# *Romans 7:1-3*

In Romans 7:1-3, Paul says, *"(1) Or are you ignorant, brethren, for I speak to those knowing the law, that the law dominates the man as long a time as he lives; (2) for the woman under a husband has been bound by the law to the husband while (he is) living, but if the husband might die, she is discharged from the law of the husband. (3) Then therefore while the husband is living she is called an adulteress if she be joined to another man; but if the husband might die, she is free from the law, so that she is not an adulteress joined to another man. "*

These verses teach, first, that the Mosaic Law "dominates" (κυριευει), *lords over, holds sway over*, and *rules* a man during his lifetime. Second, the wife has been bound to her husband by the Mosaic Law while he is living. Note, the verb translated "has been bound" (δεδεται) is in the *perfect tense* and speaks of a continuous binding from the time the marriage was enacted. Third, the death of the husband discharges (κατηργηται) the wife from the Mosaic Law binding her to him. This literally means that his death made the marriage contract *ineffective*, *invalid*, or *annulled*. Fourth, the marriage having been annulled by the husband's death, the woman is now free to be married to another man.

Please keep in mind that Paul cites the above passage as *an example of how death frees one from the Mosaic Law* to be joined to another. Likewise, identification with the death of Christ frees those once under the Law to be joined to the resurrected Christ (Rom. 7:4-6). Since this is merely a general example of how it was under the Mosaic Law, with no details or indications that it is relevant for this Church age, we call it to your attention for what it is - a Law example. The Jews under the Law were the people of God, supposedly all believers, but in this Church age the Gospel goes forth to all men, who are divided into believers and unbelievers.

On the one hand, the Law was addressed to the descendents of Abraham, Israelites, God's distinct covenant family. On the other hand, the Church is constituted of Jews and Gentiles, those from all races, nations, and backgrounds. The True Church consists of those who have been chosen in Christ before the foundation of the world (Eph. 1:4), those who are the recipients of Divine faith (Rom. 10:17; Eph. 2:8); while the church, as manifested on earth, has many who have humanistically forced their way into it, they are empty professors, unbelievers. In dealing with this subject in this Church age it is exceedingly important to distinguish between true and false believers (1 Cor. 15:2; Col. 1:23).

# *First Corinthians 7:1-40*

The seventh chapter of First Corinthians gives us the most detailed information on the subject of marriage and separation. We will exegete this chapter verse-by-verse, endeavoring to accurately bring out what it is saying.

*1."And concerning that which you wrote, it is good for a man not to touch a woman;*

In order to get adequate historical data before us, a prerequisite for interpreting this verse, we need to consider the meaning of the phrase "on account of *the has been and continuing necessity*" referred to in verse 26. This may be more briefly translated the *present necessity, present distress,* or *present affliction*. At that point in history Paul saw conditions in the world as bad and getting worse, troublous times.

Verse one implies that the Corinthians, through writing, have asked Paul several questions about the relations between men and women, marriage, separation, virgins, etc. As he begins to answer these questions he makes a general statement, "it is good for a man not to touch a woman." The Greek word translated "touch" (απτεσθαι) means to *come in contact with, to know carnally,* or *to have intercourse with*. As Paul looked at the present and impending troublous times, following this course would result in the least sorrow and grief.

*2."but on account of fornication let each one have his own wife, and let each one have her own husband."*

In spite of the impending distress, and the desirability of celibacy, Paul recognized an overriding human factor, the strength of the sexual drive which can produce fornication. Instead of fornication, which he apparently recognized as being inevitable, he rescinds his statement in verse 1, and orders each man and woman to have his/her own spouse (the imperative mode of command is used). In view of the total context of this chapter this command does not have to be applied to more than those having strong, inordinate sex drives, which would probably include the vast majority of healthy human beings.

It is interesting to note that *no limits* are stipulated here or elsewhere regarding who can marry to avoid fornication. There is no suggestion that the separated man or woman is to be deprived of the conjugal relations of marriage. If Paul had singled these persons out, wouldn't he be setting a double standard? If we refuse the privilege of marriage to separated persons, leaving them extremely vulnerable to fornication, are we guiltless if they fall into the latter?

*3."Let the husband render the obligation to the wife, and likewise the wife to the husband."*

The Greek word translated "obligation" (οφειλην) speaks of *that which is owed, due, a debt,* or *duty*. God has created the man physically and emotionally to compliment the woman physically and emotionally, and conversely, the wife with the husband. The husband is to meet the physical and emotional needs of his wife, and likewise she is to meet his needs. Marriage involves *mutual responsibilities* on the part of both the husband and wife, and here Paul orders (imperative mode) both spouses to fulfill their respective conjugal responsibilities.

*4."The woman does not have authority over her own body but the man; likewise, the man does not have authority over his own body but the woman."*

The Greek noun translated "authority" (εξουσιαζει) means to exercise *authority, power,* or *control* over something. Paul is declaring here that each spouse has power and control over the opposite spouse's body. The use of the strong adversative "but" (αλλα) emphasizes the fact that each partner in the marriage relation is to passively yield his/her body to the control of the other partner. Each person has authority over his/her mate's body when necessary to compliment their own body. Paul is speaking here of a marital relationship in which the physical and emotional needs of both parties are fully satisfied.

*5."Do not deprive one another, unless it might be out of mutual agreement for a time, that you might be devoted to prayer, and again that you might be together (same place), that Satan might not tempt you on account of your incontinence (intemperance)."*

The Greek verb translated "deprive" (αποστερειτε) literally means that the husband and wife are not to *keep from, remove from,* or *bereave* one another of their respective persons (bodies). Paul mentions one exception to this - if the husband and wife deprive one another it must be based on mutual agreement (συμφωνου). This means that they must consent, concur, and accede with one another before becoming involved in anything which would keep them apart. At the most, such an agreement would only be *for a time* (προς καιρον). Paul mentions prayer as a specific reason for temporary apartness, but not necessarily the only reason.

The statement, "that Satan might not tempt you on account of your incontinence," primarily refers to the forepart of this verse; however, in a secondary sense, it may also be applied to verses 2-4. Paul is affirming here that Satan is the one who *tempts* (πειραζη), who alluringly tests, and who enticingly proves men and women, arousing them to commit fornication. The Greek word rendered "incontinence" (ακρασιαν) suggests that Satan may tempt them because of their *lack of power, inability to master their urges,* or *rapacious appetite*. Since Paul's antidote against fornication is a fully satisfying marital relationship, and since anything that interferes with this relationship makes one more susceptible to Satan's devices, he says, "Do not deprive one another."

Paul indicates in this verse that he wants believers to have *more* than a marriage contract, he wants them to be one physically and psychologically, he wants them to be fully *satisfying* the conjugal and emotional needs of one another. This kind of a marriage utterly thwarts and defies Satan. Is this kind of a marriage the antidote

against fornication only for those who have never previously been married? Paul does not limit it to them. If marriage is God's answer to fornication, which Paul says it is, and refusal to permit marriage leads to fornication, who should bear the brunt of the guilt - the refuser or fornicator?

*6. "And this I say according to concession, and not according to commandment. "*

The Greek word translated "concession" (συγγνωμην) has the basic meaning of *know-with, fellow-feeling, hence, permission, allowance,* or *license.* The thought seems to be that there was knowing-with-the-Lord regarding what he was about to write, but it was not something he was actually commanded to write, rather he wrote it by permission, the Lord allowed him to write it, or he was given license to write it. We interpret this statement to apply primarily to verse 7; however, it could also have retroactive significance covering verses 1-5. We see what Paul writes backed by Divine authority. On the one hand, he was *not directly commanded* to write it; on the other hand, he was *permitted* to write it.

*7. "And I desire all men to be even as I myself, but each one has his own gift from God, one this and another that."*

The Greek verb for "desire" (θελω) may also be rendered *I wish, I want,* and *I would that* all men were single as I am. In the light of the present and impending troublous times, Paul sees a real advantage in being single, unencumbered, and without family responsibilities. The clear implication is that Paul had the gift of living continent as a single person. Having stated his desire for all men, he immediately says, "but each one has his own gift from God."

Paul did not try to force all men into the same physical and psychological box which was suitable for him, but recognized that men have different gifts in these areas. A few might have the gift of living single, continent, undistracted, celibate lives, but the vast majority, according to what Paul says and confirmed by history, are less likely to succumb to temptation when happily married (Matt. 19:9-12). What if the separated person does not have the gift of celibacy? Is he/she to remain unmarried in jeopardy of committing fornication? Paul's obvious answer is no, *remove the peril*, get married.

8."And I say to the unmarried and to the widows, it is good for them if they remain even as I am;"

Who are the "unmarried" (αγαμοις) referred to in this verse? Paul is the only one who uses this word in the New Testament. All five times he uses it are in this chapter (vv. 8, 11, 32, 34 twice). In verse 11, the word *unmarried* is used regarding a separated person. The word for "widows" (χηραις) refers to women who have been bereaved of their husbands, in fact, the basic meaning of this word is *bereave*.

As we have already observed, in the light of the distressful times, Paul's first choice for the unmarried and widows is that they remain single. This is the same advice he gives to all men and women at this point in time (cf. v. 1, 7). Observe, Paul does not forbid the unmarried in this verse to marry, which apparently included separated persons, but he merely says that it is "good" (καλον) for them to remain as he is. Their following this advice would, of course, depend upon the gift God had given to each of them (v. 7).

*9."but if they do not have self-control (inner power) let them marry; for it is better to marry than to burn."*

Having suggested that the unmarried and widows remain single, Paul immediately qualifies his suggestion by saying, "but if they do not have self-control let them marry." The Greek verb translated "self-control" (εγκρατευονται) is derived from the preposition "εν" prefixed to the verb "κρατευομαι," and it is in the imperative mode of command. Paul is literally commanding them, if they lack *inner power, strength,* and *might*, to get married. This statement taken at face value places no limitations on the unmarried, whether some of them were separated or not, but orders all who lack self-control to get married.

In view of the present and impending distress, marriage was not Paul's first choice for them, but if they lacked inner strength to subdue their hot passions, he adds, "it is better to marry than to burn." This context ties together the thought of *inadequate inner power to control one's sexual urge* and the thought that *marriage is an alternate to burning*. the context implies that to have a strong sexual urge is "to burn" (πυρουσθαι) with lust and desire (cf. 2 Cor. 11:29). Out of the three times Paul uses this word in his epistles, two times he uses it in this manner.

Those who are burning in sexual desire, including all unmarried and widows, regardless of background, need to recognize the peril of their position - that they are walking a tightrope between continence and incontinence, between chastity and unchastity. Even though Paul recognized that marriage had its problems at that time in history, yet he says that it is "better" (κρειττον), *superior,* and *more desirable* than traveling Perilous-Burning Road. In view of what Paul is saying in this verse *we have no authority* to prevent anyone from leaving Perilous-Burning Road for Marriage Lane.

*10."And I charge those who have been married, not I but the Lord, a wife (believing) is not to depart from a husband,"*

Since Paul only instructs believers, the wife in this verse is obviously a believer, and as such is not to "depart" (χωρισθηναι), *separate, withdraw,* or *sever* herself from her husband. The grammatical construction here is a passive infinitive, which could be more accurately translated, "a wife is not to be removed from a husband." The thought is that no *outside person or thing* is to separate the believing wife from her husband. Neither she nor anyone else is to take the initiative in severing her from her husband. Now we must keep in mind, this is *not a command* (imperative mode), but it is the statement of a *general principle*. Under normal circumstances the believing wife is to remain with her husband. This does not necessarily mean that the wife, if abusively and threateningly treated, is to endanger her physical and psychological well-being by living with a brutish husband.

*11."but even if she might be separated, let her remain unmarried or let her be reconciled to the husband, and a husband (believing) is not to leave a wife."*

This verse acknowledges that in some instances a believing wife will be separated from her husband. The use of the passive voice suggests that others would be involved, such as her family and friends, in bringing about this separation. Now if as a believer a wife separates or is separated from her husband, she has the

alternatives either to remain unmarried or to be reconciled to her husband. In this verse Paul does not specifically deal with the validity of the separation, such as fornication (cf. Matt. 5:32), neither does he say anything about the perilous plight of the woman, burning on the verge of fornication, in the event that her former husband has remarried. We logically assume that what he says in verse 9, as a safety net, would apply.

In the last part of this verse a husband is instructed not to leave a wife. The Greek word used here, translated "leave" (αφιεναι), means that he is not to *go from, forsake,* or *desert*. Again we observe, this is an infinitive, a general statement, which leaves room for leaving under impossible, abnormal circumstances. This is not an unqualified blanket command. Furthermore, if the believing husband has no recourse but to leave, nothing is said about his future marital status. Some might assume that the same orders given to the separated woman would apply to him, however, this would be based on assumption.

*12."And to the rest I say, not the Lord; if any brother has an unbelieving wife, and she is content to live with him, let him not leave her;*

Thus far in this chapter Paul has spoken about the ingredients of a fully satisfying marriage, the desirableness of remaining single in the light of the impending distress, and he has given instructions to the unmarried, widows, and the married. He addresses this verse "to the rest" (τος δε λοιποις). This Greek phrase means to the *remaining ones or those not included in the above categories*. With respect to this group, and his writing to them, Paul says, "I say, not the Lord." This means that he had not received by Divine revelation what he is about to write to this group. On the other hand, as one who had been placed into the ministry and counted faithful (1 Tim. 1:12), Paul's mind was closely tuned to the mind of the Lord on such subjects (cf. v. 25). What he says is in full accord with the spirit of *love, mercy, and grace* which saturates the Mystery Truth given for the guidance of the Church.

In this verse Paul is commanding (imperative mode) the believing husband not to "leave" (αφιετω), forsake, or desert his unbelieving wife, i.e., if she is content to live with him. The Greek word translated "content" (συνευδοκει) is derived from "συν" and "ευδοκεω" and literally means if she be *well-pleasing with*, hence, if with her husband she *thinks it good, is pleased,* or *agrees* to continue cohabiting. When one person in an already-existing marriage becomes a believer, it results in an unequally-yoked-together relationship, which believers are commanded not to enter into (v. 39; 2 Cor. 6:14); however, since they are already married, the man who becomes a believer is to continue living with his wife if she *mutually consents and agrees* to do so.

*13."And if any wife has an unbelieving husband, and he is content to live with her, let her not leave the husband."*

In this verse Paul addresses the believing wife. He uses identical verbs for *content* and *leave*, as he did in addressing the believing husband, the meanings of which we will not repeat. Again we emphasize, when a believer finds him/herself married to an unbeliever, they are *to maintain the status quo* of the marriage. This situation may result from unequally contracted marriages, the salvation of one spouse after marriage, time proving a prior-to-marriage profession to be false, and ignorance or deception.

Since the believing spouse, the wife in this verse, is a member of God's family, she is governed by the regulations of this family, which specify that she is *not to leave her unsaved mate.*

There is an aspect in the believer-unbeliever marriage which is *beyond* the believer's control. Furthermore, according to God's arrangement in this Church age, He does not dictate the lifestyle of the unbeliever. As far as God and the believer are concerned, the unbeliever in a marriage is free to act according to his/her natural will. If the unbeliever is content and satisfied to continue cohabiting with the believer, the latter should not leave or desert the marriage. In other words, the believer must not take the initiative in breaking the marriage bond.

*14. "For the unbelieving husband is set apart in the wife, and the unbelieving wife is set apart in the brother; otherwise your children are unclean, but now they are holy."*

What does Paul mean by the statement, "the unbelieving husband is set apart in the wife?" The Greek verb translated "set apart" (ηγιασται) is in the perfect tense and passive voice, and more fully translated would mean that the unsaved husband *has been and continues to be set apart, separated, sanctified, and consecrated*. This set-apartness is dependent upon the unbelieving husband's relation to his believing wife. The grammar used here may be interpreted as a locative case and translated *in the wife*, or it may be considered an instrumental case and rendered *by the wife.* The thought is that God has sovereignly set apart the unbelieving husband *in the sphere of* or *by means of* the believing wife.

In the same manner, the unbelieving wife is set apart in or by her believing husband, who in this case is called *the brother*. The same verb is used in both clauses, indicating that the believing wife and husband equally effect God's work on their unbelieving spouses. The fact that the wife or husband are believers does not in itself produce the setting apart, but is only an *obvious prerequisite* which accompanies it. The perfect tense suggests that *at a prior time* these unbelieving spouses had been set apart, and the passive voice indicates that *God did it*. The context makes it clear that these unbelieving spouses are those mentioned in verses 12-13, *those who agree with* their believing spouses to live with them.

What does Paul mean when he says that unbelievers, who are content to remain married to believers, *have been set apart* (ηγιασται)? The participle form of this word is commonly used to depict those who have been set apart unto God through faith in Jesus Christ (Acts 20:32; 26:18; 1 Cor. 1:2), but that is *not the meaning here*, for these individuals are designated as unbelievers. In speaking of apostates in the latter times, Paul says that they will be insisting on abstinence from foods which God has created for human consumption, "because every creature of God is good, and nothing is to be rejected being received with thanksgiving, for it is set apart through the word of God and prayer" (1 Tim. 4:4-5). Even though this verb is primarily used with respect to those set apart unto God in the sphere of salvation, this verse uses it in conjunction with the setting apart and cleansing of food. Likewise, Paul uses this verb with a special *undefined meaning* to describe the position of an unbeliever married to a believer.

Paul makes one point clear, if the unbelieving mates were not set apart, "otherwise your children are unclean." The Greek word translated "otherwise" (επει) literally conveys the idea of *since then, because consequently,* or *then the result would be* unclean children. The Greek word rendered "unclean" (ακαθαρτα) speaks of that which is *impure, contaminated,* and *foul.* In the Synoptic Gospels and Acts it is most commonly used of *unclean spirits* (Matt. 10:1; Mark 1:23; Luke 4:36; Acts 5:16). It is used of animals which are unclean for food (Acts 10:14, 28; 11:8). Paul uses it in a context in which he is exhorting the Corinthians *not to be yoked together with unbelievers* (2 Cor. 6:17). He also uses it between terms dealing with *sexual uncleanness* (Eph. 5:5).

Paul apparently considered unbelievers, impregnated with their sins, as being unclean. Furthermore, under normal circumstances, one unbeliever in a marriage would pass this uncleanness on to the progeny. In the believer-unbeliever marriages referred to in verses 12-13, however, we observe that the unbelievers are set apart so as not to pass this uncleanness on to their children. The children are counted as "holy" (αγια), apparently the same as children born into a believer-believer home. We do not have much information on this subject, but of one thing we are certain, this is an example of God *extending His grace an extra mile.*

*15. "But if the unbeliever departs, let him depart; the brother or the sister has not been bound in such cases, but God has called you in peace."*

Having explained what the believer is to do if his/her unbelieving spouse wants to continue the marriage, Paul now deals with a believer's response if his/her unbelieving spouse departs from the marriage. Paul's answer is terse, one word in the Greek, translated, "let him depart" (χωριζεσθω). Paul puts this in the form of a *command* (imperative mode): don't haggle, but let him *separate, withdraw,* and *sever* himself from the marriage. In actual practice this departing may manifest itself in many ways, such as immediate or gradual *desertion*, refusal of support, withdrawal from cohabitation, and a general failing to meet one's marital obligations (vv. 3-5; 1 Tim. 5:8).

In marriages where the unbeliever departs, such as Paul is speaking of here, "the brother or the sister has not been bound." Paul's use of the verb translated "bound" in the *perfect tense* and *passive voice* has very significant ramifications in this verse. He says that "in such cases" (εν τοις τοιουτοις), situations such as he is describing, in similar circumstances, the brother or sister believer "has not been bound" (ου δεδουλωται). This phrase consists of the perfect verb rendered has been bound, enslaved, and attached, which is negated by the word translated "not." This apparently refers back to the time when the man and woman were outwardly joined in marriage. When the unbelieving spouse departs from the marriage, Paul uses the negative adverb "not" (ου) to declare that the believing brother or sister *has not been bound*, i.e., that the marriage had never been consummated from the Divine point of view.

As a part of this context, the statement, "but God has called you in peace," has significant implications. In Colossians 3:15, Paul throws light on what he means here, for he says, "And let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, unto which also

you were called in one body." This makes it clear that peace is *in the sphere of the Body of Christ*. Two believers in the Body of Christ bring this peace into their marriage; it *rules* (βραβευετω), *arbitrates*, and *governs* in their marital relations. Since the unbelieving spouse is not in the Body, and does not have this peace, Paul says, "let him depart." Rather than having a believer living with an unbeliever in a rancorous relationship, Paul would sooner see the unbeliever depart. This passage implies that he had a *strong antipathy* against all bitter and abusive human relations (Eph. 4:2-3).

*16."For what do you know, wife, if you shall save the husband? Or what do you know, husband, if you shall save the wife?"*

Paul does not want the saved person in a marriage to act precipitously, for in the process of time he/she may be the instrument through whom God impresses His Word upon the mind of the unsaved mate (cf. 1 Peter 3:1). The phrase "For what do you know" (τι γαρ οιδας) or *for how do you know* implies both *God's sovereignty* in salvation as well as *our imperative* to live and teach the Gospel. Neither the believing wife nor husband knows whether their unsaved spouses are a part of God's elect; therefore, they must make the Gospel known to all of them through word and deed.

What Paul says in this verse is in full accord with what he has said. Through all that has preceded he has been positively affirming that the believing spouse is *to hang in the marriage*, not to take the initiative in breaking it, but to hold it together by mutually agreeing with the contented unbelieving spouse. According to what Paul has said thus far, the only way for a marriage to be dissolved is by the *death* of one of the spouses or by the unbelieving spouse *departing* from it. The Greek grammar used indicates that the departure of the unbeliever voids, annuls, and rescinds the outward contract which bound the spouses together. It appears that in such cases it was merely a human contract, void of Divine approval, and nonrestrictive as far as the believer, the former spouse, is concerned.

*17."Except to each as the Lord has distributed, as God has called each, so let him walk; and so I command in all the churches."*

The Greek phrase translated "except" (ει μη) may also be rendered *unless* or *apart from*. We logically look for a connection between what Paul says in this and the preceding verse. We suggest that his thought is that the unsaved spouse will respond according to the faith "distributed" (εμερισεν), *divided*, and bestowed upon him/her. Humanly conceived and generated faith operates on the premise of works, and as such, cannot save, for salvation is by *grace* through faith and not out of self-works (Eph. 2:8-9). As the believing spouses shared and lived the Gospel, the salvation of their unsaved mates was inseparable from God imparting to them faith to believe it.

Now let us look at the clause, "as God has called each, so let him walk." The Greek word translated "has called" (κεκληκεν), *summoned,* and *invited* is commonly used in conjunction with God's call to salvation (Rom. 8:30; 9:24; 1 Cor. 1:9; Gal. 1:15). Paul's emphasis here is on the fact that God had called each one unto salvation, but it goes beyond that; it also refers to their *status, position,* and *earthly calling* when they received their heavenly calling. The Greek adverb translated "as" (ως) conveys the

idea of *even as, like as,* or *according as* each one was when God called you to Himself, "so let him walk."

The adverb rendered "so" (ουτως), which precedes "let him walk," means that the one who has been called is to walk *in the same manner, in the same way,* and remain in the same occupation in which he was when called to salvation. This adverb "ουτως" solidly identifies the person's present walk with his walk at the time God called him. As Paul exhorts them to maintain the status quo, one thing he is trying to discourage is an altering of their marital relations; if they are single or married he prefers them to remain such in the light of the present distress (vv. 7-8, 10, 26-27).

Paul makes it clear that he has not singled out the Corinthians, as those who particularly need this advice, but he says, "so I command in all the churches." Again we observe that the Greek adverb translated "so" (ουτως) means that in the same manner and way he has advised and commanded all the churches. In other words, the things he is writing the Corinthians about were commonly discussed in all the churches, special emphasis being placed on maintaining the status quo (cf. 2 Thess. 3:6-8). The Greek verb translated "I command" (διατασσομαι) means that Paul *precisely arranged, prescribed,* and *charged* them to remain in the calling in which they were called (cf. v. 20; Eph. 4:1). As we have already indicated, considering the preceding context, this obviously included *staid* single and marital relations.

*18."Has any has-been-circumcised one been called? Let him not be uncircumcised. Has any been called in uncircumcision? Let him not be circumcised."*

We have very literally translated the perfect, passive participle as a has-been-circumcised person. If this person was called unto salvation after he had been circumcised, he should be satisfied with his circumcised status, and is commanded not to be "uncircumcised" (επισπασθω), i.e., to obliterate the circumcision by artificially *pulling upon* and *drawing upon* an extension of the foreskin. On the other hand, if a person is called when he is still uncircumcised, he should recognize that circumcision has no spiritual value (Gal. 5:6; 6:15), and Paul commands him not to be circumcised. Summarizing, they are to maintain the status quo in the area of circumcision.

*19."The circumcision is nothing, and the uncírcumcísion is nothing, but keeping commandments of God."*

Neither the rite of circumcision, nor the fact that one is uncircumcised, has any spiritual significance in this present Church age. The Greek word for "nothing" (ουδεν) means that it is *not one, not a single thing,* or *of no account.* Having declared that circumcision is a nonentity in this dispensation of grace, using the strong contrasting "but" (αλλα), Paul says that it is "keeping commandments of God." This is an exact translation, and it literally means that circumcision was the keeping of *some* or *certain* commandments contained in the Law of Moses. Since in this Church age we are not under the Law but under grace (Rom. 6:14);

therefore, when God calls a person to salvation, Paul commands him not to be circumcised.

*20."Let each one remain in this, in the calling in which he was called."*

The verb translated "remain" (μενετω) means to *abide, continue,* and *stay.* The nominative pronoun rendered "each one" (εκαστος), together with the verb in the present tense and imperative mode, means that Paul is commanding them to continue to remain, stay, and abide in the calling in which they were when they were called. The Greek noun rendered "calling" (κλησει) generally speaks of a call to a *spiritual position* (1 Cor. 1:26; Eph. 4:1), with the exception of this verse, in which it refers to the called person's position as one who is *circumcised or uncircumcised, a slave,* or *a freeman*. Paul was very apprehensive of the dire effect believers leaving their respective callings could have on the Gospel.

*21."Were you called being a slave? Let it not concern you; but if also you are able to become free, use it rather."*

Here Paul speaks about the person who was *a slave* when he was called unto salvation. Now that he is saved, what attitude should he take toward his socio-economic position? Paul says, don't let it "concern you" (σοι μελετω), *be a care to you,* or *occupy your thinking.* We must keep in mind that Paul did not want conversion to Christianity to be the first step toward social revolution and economic irresponsibility. The letter to Philemon gives us superb information regarding his cautious handling of a converted runaway and the restoring of him to his master. If a slave's calling to salvation became equated with a refusal to serve his master, the progress of the Gospel would have been severely hampered. This is why Paul commands converts to maintain the status quo, with the right frame of mind, doing all things as unto the Lord (Col. 3:23).

Having commanded the converted slaves not to be concerned about their status as slaves, Paul adds, "but if also you are able to become free, use it rather." The fact that he uses the strong adversative "αλλα," which is translated *but*, implies that he was vitally interested in their freedom if they were able to obtain it in a peaceful, nonviolent manner. The Greek verb translated "you are able" (δυνασαι) is in the present tense, and it means that any time a believing slave is *able, has the power,* or *the ability* to become a freeman, he should use it. We must not misinterpret this statement to mean that Paul is approving the slave's use of physical force to gain his freedom. This would be diametrically opposed to what he says in his epistles (Eph. 6:5-6; Col. 3:25; 1 Tim. 6:1-2; Titus 2:9-10). The point Paul is making in this verse is that a slave should take advantage of any peaceful means which would liberate him.

*22."For the slave who has been called in the Lord is the Lord's freedman; likewise, the one who has been called being a freeman is a slave of Christ."*

Paul is not speaking of just any slave, but of a specific one, an in-the-Lord slave. The verb translated "has been called" (κλνθεις) is in the aorist tense and passive voice, which indicates that at a given point in time in the past God sovereignly *called, summoned,* and *drew* this person to the Redeemer, Jesus Christ. As one

who has been redeemed, delivered from sin, he is referred to as a *freed-from man*. In the previous verse, the slave who was liberated from slavery was designated a *freeman* (ελευθερος), but in this verse the slave who was liberated from sin is called a *freed-from man* (απελευθερος). The Greek preposition "απο" prefixed to the noun "ελευθερος" emphasizes the fact that the slave in Christ is a freed-from-sin person who *belongs to the Lord*.

In the second part of this verse, Paul says, "likewise, the one who has been called being a freeman is a slave of Christ." The adverb rendered "likewise" (ομοιως) means that *in like manner* or *similarly* the same principle applies to the freeman. When God's grace reaches out and calls, summons, and *brings* a freeman to the cross, through the effectual energizing of the Holy Spirit, he is a slave of Christ. The use of the genitive case, which denotes possession, makes it clear that this one who was once a freeman in society is *owned and possessed by Christ, he belongs to Christ.* Paul continuously refers to himself as a slave of Christ (Rom. 1:1; Gal. 1:10).

*23."You have been bought with a price; do not be slaves of men."*

The Greek verb translated "you have been bought" (ηγορασθητε) is in the aorist tense and passive voice, which means that at a point in past time they were *purchased, acquired,* and *redeemed* by God the Father through the Blood of His Son (1 Cor. 6:20; Rev. 5:9). The *you*, part of this verb, applies to all believers, both slaves and freemen. All were totally depraved and dead in sin (Eph. 2:1-3), all had the love and mercy of God extended to them (Eph. 2:4), and all had the price of Christ's Blood paid for their redemption (Eph. 1:7).

In view of the fact that we believers had been bought with a price, Paul says, "do not be slaves of men." This may be translated more literally, "do not *you* be slaves of men. God's primary concern is not with the people of the world, how they live, but with His elect (2 Tim. 2:10), with His people who have been bought with the price of His Son's Blood, with those who are in the category of the *you* in this verse. The phrase translated "do not be" (μη γινεσθε) contains a present, imperative verb, which means that Paul is giving them a *continuous command* to never allow themselves to become the slaves of men, those who belong to men. This verb is in the middle voice, which means that they in conjunction with the Holy Spirit have the *responsibility* of not becoming slaves of men. Since we all are the slaves of Christ, what a disservice it is to Him to dabble in serving men!

*24."Each one in that which he was called, brethren, in this let him remain with God."*

This is an excellent summary statement of Paul's main thesis in this paragraph (vv. 17-24). The Greek word rendered "each one" (εκαστος), is limited to, but includes all those who have been called. Collectively, Paul designates them as brethren. His repetitive emphasis here is that every one is to remain "in that which" (εν ω) he was called, i.e., in his distinct *calling* (εκληθη). In the light of this paragraph and what precedes it, this may be applied to one's status in relation to marriage, circumcision, uncircumcision, and being a slave or freeman.

With regard to the person's distinct calling, which is not necessarily limited to the above mentioned items, Paul says, "in this let him remain with God." This is the second time he uses this same present, imperative verb to press home the need for each believer to *continue* and *stay* in the physical category in which he was when he was saved. He does add two significant Greek words at the end of this verse, namely, "παρα θεω," which may be translated either *with God* or *beside God*. Granted, the physical circumstances of some of these early believers may have been very difficult, but in their *together-with-God relation*, recognizing His Divine presence, they would be encouraged and comforted (2 Cor. 1:3-4; 7:6).

*25."And concerning the virgins I do not have a commandment of the Lord, butIgive my opinion as one who has been given mercy by the Lord to be faithful."*

The contents of this paragraph presuppose that the Corinthians had asked Paul some questions about virgins. His answer is that he does not have a specific commandment "of the Lord" (κυριου), that *belongs to the Lor*d or that is the *Lord's own* commandment on the subject. At that point in time the Lord had not revealed information to him on the particular issue of virgins. Indirectly, this is a very significant statement favoring the fact that Paul's normal writing consisted of the commandments of the Lord.

The Greek word translated "virgins" (παρθενων) is used some 15 times in the New Testament. In every instance, when its meaning is clearly defined, it always refers to a *chaste woman* rather than a man (Matt. 1:23; 25:7; Acts 21:9; 1 Cor. 7:28, 34, 36; 2 Cor. 11:2; Rev. 14:4). In view of this precedent we interpret that the virgins of this chapter were girls or women who had never been involved in sexual relations with men.

Having stated that he does not have a commandment of the Lord regarding virgins, Paul says, "but I give my opinion as one who has been given mercy by the Lord to be faithful." The Greek word translated "opinion" (γνωμην) is used 6 times by Paul, and always has the basic meaning of *mind*, hence, *thinking, judgment,* and *advice*. Paul uses this word back in chapter 1, verse 10, where he says, "that you may be perfected in the same mind (νοι) and the same *thinking* (γνωμη)." In this context the word translated "opinion" (γνωμη) has a very similar meaning to the Greek word for "mind" (νοι). In lieu of the Lord's commandment regarding virgins, out of a mind being brought into captivity to Christ (2 Cor. 10:5), Paul gives his opinion, judgment, and thoughts on the subject (cf. 2 Cor. 8:10; Philemon 14).

The value of Paul's opinion is based on the fact that he had "been given mercy by the Lord to be faithful." The Greek participle translated "one who has been given mercy" (ηλεημενος) is in the perfect tense and passive voice, and means that God had extended *pity, compassion,* and *clemency* to Paul. Through the extension of His mercy to Paul, God caused him to be faithful, i.e., a faithful one. First Timothy 1:12, throws additional light on who produced this faithfulness in Paul, for we read, "because he counted me faithful having placed me into a ministry." The aorist participle makes it clear that *after* God had placed Paul into a ministry, then, as a result, He counted him faithful. As one who was the recipient of God's mercy, and

consequently made faithful by God, his opinion comes from a God-wrought-upon mind which is in alignment with God.

*26. "I think therefore that this is good on account of the present distress, that it is good for a man so to be."*

The Greek verb translated "I think" (νομιζω) means that it *seems* or *appears* to me, hence, I *deem, presume,* or *suppose*. In Acts 21:29, this verb is used to depict the mindset of the Asian Jews in Jerusalem, who were *thinking, presuming,* and *supposing* (ενομιζον) that Paul had taken Trophimus into the temple. It is used in First Timothy 6:5, pertaining to men who were turning away from the truth, who were *thinking, presuming,* and *supposing* that godliness is a source of gain. At the time Paul was writing this epistle he thought it good to maintain the status quo.

The reason Paul gives this advice is "on account of the present distress." The Greek noun translated "distress" (αναγκην) basically means *to compress*, and it conveys the idea of *necessity, compulsion, pressure,* and *affliction*. The Greek participle rendered "present" (ενεστωσαν) is derived from the preposition "εν" and the verb "ιστημι." It is in the perfect tense, and it literally means *has and continues to stand in, stand upon,* and *to be present.* In Galatians 1:4, Paul uses this word in speaking of "the present evil age." In Second Thessalonians 2:2, Paul warns against those affirming that "the day of the Lord is present." The basic meaning of this word in conjunction with the perfect tense refers to that which is *already existing*, hence that which is present. Summarizing, in view of the distressful and afflictive conditions existing in the world when he was writing this letter, Paul advises believers to remain as they are.

In further clarifying the meaning of this verse, note the following literal thought flow, "I think therefore this exists good. . that it is good for a man so to be." In this case we interpret the neuter article as referring back to the word "good" (καλον). The adverb "ουτως" with the infinitive "ειναι" may also be translated thus to be, to be in the same manner, or likewise to be. Thanks to the clarity of the context, we feel that we can confidently affirm that Paul wants them to remain *like they are* or *in their same manner of life.* In other words, they are to *maintain the status quo.* Why should they adopt this passive, nonchanging lifestyle? Paul's answer is, "on account of the present distress." With a change in the "present distress" (ενεστωσαν αναγκην), or in Paul's interpretation of it, there could be a change in his status quo advice.

*27."Have you been bound to a wife? Do not seek a loosing. Have you been loosed from a wife? Do not seek a wife."*

The Greek verb translated "have you been bound" (δεδεσαι) is in the perfect tense and passive voice. Granted that a man has been *bound, tied,* and *married* to a woman when the Corinthians receive this epistle, what should he do about it? Paul's answer is to *maintain his marital status*. He is not to "seek" (ζητει), *endeavor, strive for,* and *desire a loosing* (λυσιν), release, or nullifying of the marriage. Paul's point is that if you are married, remain married, maintain your married status quo.

In the last half of this verse Paul addresses the person who has been *loosed, freed,* and *divorced* from a woman. Obviously, the language used here refers to a man who was once married but who has become unmarried, hence, *has become loosed* (λελυσαι) and free. What is Paul's attitude toward this separated or divorced believer? He should remain in his loosed-from-a-wife, single position, continue as he is, i.e., maintain the status quo in which he is when this letter is received. In the light of the immediate context, Paul gives this advice on account of the present distress.

*28."But even if you may marry, you have not sinned; and if the virgin may marry, she has not sinned. But such ones shall have affliction in the flesh, but I spare you."*

In the light of the context we prefer to translate the introduction to this verse, "but even if" (εαν δε και) you may marry. The contextual relation of this statement implies that Paul is primarily referring to those who have been loosed in verse 27. He gives no details as to how they were loosed, whether it resulted from annulment, separation, or divorce. His preference for them is to remain unmarried, but if they choose to marry, they have "not sinned" (ουκ ημαρτες), *not missed the mark, erred, nor are they guilty of wrongdoing.* This verse states no prohibitions regarding the remarriage of the man who has been loosed from his wife.

Paul began this paragraph dealing with virgins (v. 25), and was temporarily deviated, but is again on the subject. He has been encouraging all believers to remain as they are, to maintain the status quo, but "if the virgin may marry, she has not sinned." The same Greek verb is used here, in the aorist tense, as used regarding the loosed man in verse 27; neither the man nor virgin has sinned or committed a wrongdoing by marrying. The implication is that the loosed man is just as free to remarry as the virgin is to marry.

Paul now proceeds to explain the main advantage of remaining single. He says that "such ones shall have affliction in the flesh." The phrase "such ones" (οι τοιουτοι) refers to both men and women who marry. In view of the present distress he is certain that in the future they *will have "affliction"* (θλιψω), *tribulation, physical pressures,* and *trials*. He says that these will be "in the flesh," in the sphere of the flesh, such as persecution, maltreatment, and deprivation of the necessities for sustaining both their lives and the lives of their children (cf. Matt. 20:19-20; Luke 21:20-24).

Recognizing that they were already engulfed in times of pressure and distress, and being aware of the lowering disaster clouds hovering over Jerusalem, Paul apparently felt that it was not a good time to be getting married and to raise a family. At the same time Paul leaves the choice of to marry or not to marry up to the individual believer. To those who decide to marry, he says, "I spare you." The Greek verb rendered "I spare" (φειδομαι), as used here, means that Paul *would* that they don't have to go through the sufferings which he sees on the horizon. In a broader sense, in Paul's effort to get them to remain as he is, single, he is trying to spare them from, help them to avoid, the afflictive lot of the married.

*29."But this I say, brethren, the time has been shortened; henceforth that both those having wives may be as those not having,"*

In this verse Paul continues thinking about the present distress; things will tend to get worse in the latter days, and then the consummation will come with the passing by of the fashion of this world. In a very personal sense, he calls them "brethren" (αδελφοι), and shares with them his feeling that the things of this world are going to increasingly lose their value.

The clause, "the time has been shortened," is very important in understanding the thrust of what Paul is saying here. The perfect participle translated "has been shortened" (συνεσταλμενος) is derived from the Greek preposition "συν" and the verb "στελλω" and means that the time has been *drawn together, contracted,* and *shrunk,* hence*, shortened.* It seems that Paul now envisioned the appearance of the rapture as nearer than previously (1 Thess. 4:13-18). In fact, the time is so near that those who have wives will be as those not having them; therefore, a good reason to maintain the status quo. Here we see a blending of the *present distress, shortened time,* and *appearance of Christ.*

*30."and those weeping as not weeping, and those rejoicing as not rejoicing, and those buying as not possessing,"*

In this verse we have a series of *three sets* of positive and negative present participles. That which the positive, the first, participle says they will be doing is *canceled out* by the negative, the second, participle. Paul seems to be saying that in a short time what individuals are doing will be as though they were not doing it. This appears to add up to a *cessation of all things* for believers in relation to this earth (cf. 1 Thess. 4:16-17).

Now let us briefly exegete this verse. The phrase "those weeping" (οι κλαιοντες) may be translated *the ones weeping*, shedding tears, or crying. The time is coming when they will be "as" (ως), *like as,* or *even as* not weeping. The phrase "those rejoicing" (οι χαιροντες) may also be rendered the ones rejoicing, glad, and full of joy. The time is soon when this happy attitude will be as though it never was. The phrase "those buying" (οι αγοραζοντες) may likewise be translated *the ones buying, purchasing, and acquiring.* The time is near when they will be as those not "possessing" (κατεχοντες), *owning*, and *having*. That which one buys in this world is *owned only while he is on this earth*. Removal and transference from this earth categorizes the believer as owning no earthly thing (Phil. 3:20-21; Col. 3:1-4).

*31."and those using the world as not fully using; for the fashion of this world is passing by."*

The phrase "those using" (οι χρωμενοι) may, as above, be rendered *the ones using, utilizing,* or *making use of* the world. This may be interpreted as using both its inexpendable and expendable resources. Either using what it organically or inorganically produces would be consistent with Paul's statement, "not fully using" it. The phrase translated "not fully using" (μη καταχρωμενοι) is derived from the preposition "κατα" and the verb "χραομαι." This verb is the same as that used in the forepart of this verse. Prefixing the preposition "κατα" gives it the meaning of *not*

*fully using it, not thoroughly using it,* or *not using it up.* In view of the shortness of the time, Paul's probable thought is that they won't have time to exhaust the potential of the world.

Now let us examine the statement, "the fashion of this world is passing by." The Greek word for "fashion" (σχημα) refers to the *external form, shape,* and *appearance* of the world (cf. Phil. 2:8). Paul says that the form of the world is "passing by" (παραγει), present tense, is *in the process of passing by.* The verb which we have translated "passing by" (παραγει) is derived from the preposition "παρα" and the verb "αγω" and literally means is *leading by, passing by,* or *going by*. In the Synoptic Gospels and the Gospel of John it is consistently used with the meaning of passing by (Matt. 9:9; Mark 2:14; John 9:1). Likewise, in the Septuagint the meaning of *passing or going by* aligns best with the contexts in which it is used (1 Sam. 16:9; Psalms 128:8; 134:4). In the classical Greek its most common meaning is *to lead beside or by, to lead away* from a given location, and *to change or alter*. Its meaning in the Greek Papyri is in accordance with the above cited sources.

In view of this evidence, why have most of the translations attributed the meaning of *passing away* to this verb? First, because the precedent was established in certain early translations, and even though problems may have been recognized by later translators, most are slow and reticent to make changes. Second, those who hold to the translation *passing away* cite as evidence the verse before us (1 Cor. 7:31) and First John 2:8 and 17, which do not have definitive contexts in which to determine the meaning of this verb. We prefer to translate it according to its prevalent meaning in the Four Gospels, namely, *passing by*, tempered by the meaning of *changing* or *altering* observed in the classical Greek.

Paul makes no suggestion in his epistles that this "world" (κοσμος), the physical cosmos as we know it, is going to pass away or be dissolved. On the other hand, as the use of the present tense indicates, the external form and appearance of the cosmos is continuously being *altered and changed by the passing by* forces of water, wind, and thermodynamics. What Paul is saying here is in full accord with our current scientific understanding of the cosmos on which we live - it is constantly undergoing *passing-by-changes*.

Now that we have looked at the "world" (κοσμος) from a physical point of view, we need to also consider the metaphorical meaning of this noun. The word "κοσμος" is commonly used to depict the *inhabitants on the earth* (Rom. 11:15; 1 Cor. 1:20; 2 Cor. 5:19). The devil is the ruler of this world system which is contrary to God (John 12:31; 14:30; Col. 2:8; cf. 2 Cor. 4:4). In view of the *present distress* and the *shortened time*, Paul may have in mind the *passing by and changing forms* taking place in the Satanic world system; the destruction of Jerusalem (Matt. 24:1-2), the great tribulation (Rev. 7:14), and the judgment of the nations (Matt. 25:31-46), etc., that which would precede the establishment of the Messianic Kingdom. Also, we could include in this the alterations in the form of the world resulting from the removal of curse conditions from the earth (Rom. 8:21).

As we summarize what Paul says in this verse, we must keep in mind that he is writing from the vantage point of what he calls *the present distress* and *the shortened time*. If we knew exactly what he means by these two phrases, we would have a significant cue to his intended meaning of the clause, "the fashion of this world is passing by," for it is a direct outgrowth of these two phrases, particularly, of the latter, that "the time has been shortened." Our interpretation of changes in both the physical and metaphorical world system should be comprehensive enough to cover the intended meaning. Don't forget, what Paul has said here has the purpose of reinforcing his main thesis - maintain the status quo.

*32."But I want you to be without concern. The unmarried man is concerned about the things of the Lord, how he may please the Lord;"*

The first part of this verse specifically states why Paul did not want believers at that point of time in history to become entangled in family affairs. With the turmoil and tumultuous conditions getting worse, he was trying to keep believers from getting bogged down in a swamp of worldly concerns. He declares, "I want" (θελω), *wish, desire,* and *would* that you may be *without concern*. The Greek noun translated "without concern" (αμεριμνους) conveys the basic idea of not dividing the mind, *not having two-part thinking, or not being pulled between two mindsets.* Paul does not want them to be *anxious ones, those who are in a state of anxiety,* torn between adequately providing for and protecting their spouse and family and faithfully serving the Lord.

In describing exactly what he means, Paul says that "the unmarried man (masculine gender) is concerned about the things of the Lord." The Greek verb rendered "concerned" (μεριμνα) means that he is *anxious, cares about,* and is *solicitous for* the things which belong to the Lord. He is interested in "how" (πως), in *what way,* in *what manner*, or *by what means* he may please the Lord. The Greek word for "please" (αρεση) means that the unmarried believer is concerned about having *the Lord's smile of approval* on what he does, he courts the approval of the Lord instead of men. In teaching the Word to the Thessalonians, Paul emphasized how it was necessary for them "to walk and to please God" (1 Thess. 4:1; cf. 2 Tim. 2:4).

*33."but the man who has been married is concerned about the things of the world, how he may please the wife,"*

We have translated the aorist, masculine participle, used together with the masculine article, as "the man who has been married." The emphasis is, as one who has been married, this is the way he acts, "he is concerned about the things of the world." The Greek verb for "concerned" (μεριμνα) is the same as the verb in the preceding verse, which means that the married man's concern, care, and anxiety is primarily focused on the world. The implication is that supporting a wife, together with children, required full-time involvement in the commercial world.

From what Paul says here the main object of the married man is "how he may please the wife." As the unmarried man's object is to please the Lord, Paul uses identical language to indicate that the married man's object is to please his wife.

The implication of what Paul says here is that *husbands think* their wives are pleased with the things of this world; therefore, they make the obtaining of these "things" (τα) the priority in their lives.

Is Paul speaking in general terms here or has experience taught him that this is the way it is. In view of the fact many or most of the overseers, elders, and ministers were married (1 Tim. 3:2, 12; Titus 1:6), and faithfully serving the Lord, we conclude that Paul is speaking in hypothetical, general terms here. Paul's hypothesis is based on the *time available* to the single person in contrast to the married person. On this basis the single person is free to serve the Lord in contrast to the married person who is obligated to support his family (1 Tim. 5:8). We must again remind ourselves that what Paul is writing here is in the light of the present distress, and is not necessarily equally applicable to normal times. He desires believers to maintain the status quo and to remain free of marital encumbrances (vv. 7, 17, 26).

*34."and he is divided. And the unmarried woman and the virgin is concerned about the things of the Lord, that she may be holy both in body and in spirit; but the woman who has been married is concerned about the things of the world, how she may please the husband."*

The first part of this verse, the clause "and he is divided," is the last part of the previous verse. The verb translated "he is divided" (μεμεριστται) is in the perfect tense and passive voice and may also be rendered *he has been parted, he has been fragmented,* or *he has been separated.* The married man who professes to belong to the Lord, and at the same time is concerned about the things of the world in order that he may please his wife, is a divided person, one pulled in two directions, a spiritual schizophrenic (cf. Col. 1:18; Matt. 6:24).

Now we observe that like the unmarried man, "the unmarried woman and the virgin is concerned about the things of the Lord." Again we note that it is the unattached, unobligated, and free person who is at liberty to undividedly be concerned about the things of the Lord. The purpose of her concern, as expressed by "ινα" with the subjunctive, is that "she may be holy in both body and spirit." This statement of purpose indicates that the first step in pleasing the Lord involves a *likeness in being with Him*, i.e., being holy even as He is holy (1 Peter 1:16). In this Church age, which is a dispensation of grace (Eph. 3:2), Christian service pleasing to God *grows out of our righteous and holy position in Christ* (2 Cor. 5:21). As those who have been made righteous by the grace of God, we are in essence righteous, and as a consequence are to live in a holy manner pleasing to God. This holy life includes both a holy mindset (in spirit), and a holy and pure body (in body). All holiness is implanted and produced in believers through the Holy Spirit energizing in the inner man (Eph. 3:16-17).

Like the married man, "the woman who has been married is concerned about the things of the world, how she may please the husband." We have the same grammatical construction here as pertaining to the above married man. With respect to the man we emphasized his need to be concerned about the things of the world in conjunction with his obligation for the wife, who had the responsibility of

being a homemaker and a child-raiser (1 Tim. 5:14), which probably involved her in many of the physical things of this world. Some husbands and wives undoubtedly had more free time from the things of the world than others; however, Paul is not dealing with details here. As we have already suggested, he is dealing with a *broad general principle* based on the hypothesis that married men and women have worldly obligations which deprive them of time to please the Lord. In view of the present distress and shortened time, he wants them to remain as free as possible to serve the Lord.

*35."And this I say for the profit of you yourselves, not that I might cast a noose upon you, but for that which is decorous and promotive of waiting on the Lord without distraction."*

Why has Paul written what he has in the above verses? Is it because he has the gift of being a confirmed bachelor (v. 7), and he wants to force everyone else into the same mold? Paul's own answer to these questions is, "And this I say for the profit of you yourselves." The Greek noun rendered "profit" (συμφορον) means that Paul has shared these things with them for their *advantage, expedience,* and *benefit*. Through the use of the two adjacent pronouns "υμων αυτων," translated you yourselves, he emphasizes that what he is saying is solely for their benefit. Regardless of the possibility of being misunderstood and criticized, Paul did not cringe from speaking truth spiritually beneficial to others (cf. Acts 20:20, 27).

Negatively speaking, Paul says, I have not written the above "that I might cast a noose upon you." The Greek word rendered "noose" (βροχον) speaks of a *loop which cinches around one*, that which is *used for strangling or hanging,* or *a snare*. The Greek verb translated that "I might cast upon" is derived from the preposition "επι" prefixed to the verb "βαλλω," and it literally means that *I might cast or throw upon*, hence, it gives us the picture of *throwing a lasso upon an animal* to entrap it. The use of the "ινα" with the subjunctive mode makes it clear - Paul's *purpose was not* to throw out a noose or lasso upon them to entrap them into remaining single.

Positively speaking, Paul's purpose was to further "that which is decorous and promotive of waiting on the Lord without distraction." The Greek word rendered "decorous" (ευσχημον) means that Paul wanted to encourage *that which appeared good, which was honorable,* and *reputable.* The Greek word translated "promotive of waiting" (ευπαρεδρον) gives us a picture of *one sitting by ready to assist, one who is constantly attending,* and *one who is assiduously devoted* to the Lord. The adverb rendered "without distraction" (απερισπαστως) means *not to be diverted, not to be sidetracked,* or in this context *not to be overbusy*. In view of these enlarged meanings Paul is telling them that his purpose is to encourage them in that which appears good and honorable and to get them to constantly give attendance and assistance to the Lord and to do this without being diverted and overbusy.

*36. ”But if anyone thinks that he behaves unseemly toward his virgin, if he may exceed the point (of self-control), so that he is also obligated, let him do what he desires; he does not sin; let them marry."*

The many different translations of this verse must indeed be perplexing to the average English reader. The grammatical construction of this verse, plus the surrounding context, affirm that the confusion which has been produced is inexcusable. The main subject of the verse is a passionate man's relation to his virgin, lady friend, which appears to be on the brink of getting out of control.

Now let us exegete the clause, "But if anyone thinks that he behaves unseemly toward his virgin." The phrase, "if anyone thinks" (ει τις νομιζει), *if anyone acknowledges, regards,* or *deems,* implies that it is left up to the male believer to evaluate his thoughts, feelings, and actions toward the woman he is courting. That which the thinking is focused on is whether his behavior is "unseemly" (ασχημονειν), *indecorous, indecent,* and *worthy of censure*. The preposition translated "toward" (επι) has the basic idea of on the basis of, i.e., with regard to his virgin. The use of the reflexive pronoun "αυτου" in the genitive case indicates that *the virgin is his,* she *belongs to him*, she is a woman he is regularly seeing or courting.

The statement, "if he may exceed the point," is vital to understanding the meaning of this verse. The key word in this verse is "υπερακμος," which we have translated *exceed the point*. This Greek word is derived from the preposition "υπερ" prefixed to the word "ακμη," which may mean the *point of a weapon, a point in time, the point when fruit is ripe and in its prime*, hence, that which is *the pinnacle or highest point or degree*. When the preposition "υπερ" is prefixed to this word it conveys the idea of *out beyond the highest point or to surpass the highest point or degree.* Paul is using this word in this verse to describe a man who has a super-sex-drive threatening his continent relation with the virgin woman he is courting. A believer who is in this category is to acknowledge his problem in the light of Christian standards, *absolutely no fornication,* and rather than burn in passion-on-the-verge-of-sin (v. 9) he is to marry his virgin.

It is not easy to confidently grasp the intended meaning of the Greek clause translated "so that he is also obligated." This may also be translated, "and thus he is obligated to be" or "and so he is indebted to." The adverb rendered "so" (ουτως) is most commonly used to identify what is being said with what has been said, hence, *thus, so, in the same way* he is obligated. The verb translated "he is obligated" (οφειλει) basically means *he owes, is indebted, and is bound* to do something. This clause does not give the details of what he is obligated to do. In view of the most basic meaning of "γινεσθαι" the primary interpretation is that he is obligated to what he is, to acknowledge his hyper-passionate condition. The secondary interpretation is that he is *obligated to do what is necessary*, to marry his virgin (cf. Rom. 7:3-4).

Finally, with regard to the man who is finding it difficult to properly relate to the virgin woman he is courting, Paul says, "let him do what he desires; he does not sin; let them marry." The Greek word for "desires" (θελει) means that he is to do what he *wills, wishes,* or *wants* to do. The Greek verb translated "let him do" (ποιειτω) is in the present tense and imperative mode, which is a command to act, to clean up his act. After Paul's encouraging them not to marry, in the light of the

present distress, and now, in view of the super-passionate circumstances, ordering him to marry, Paul adds that in doing this *he does not sin*. At that particular point in time marriage was not Paul's choice, his ideal, for believers (vv. 1, 7, 17, 26, 27), neither was it a sin for them to marry (v. 28).

The Greek verb translated "let them marry" (γαμειτωσαν) is in the present tense and imperative mode. The use of the imperative mode indicates that this is a *command*, and the present tense suggests that this command applies to all like situations. Apart from using the aorist tense, Paul gives the same command in verse 9, directing it to those who lack self-control. These two verses are dealing with the same basic issue - passion which is dangerously testing one's will power.

*37. "But the one who has stood firm in his heart, not having necessity, but has authority concerning his own will, and he has determined this in his own heart, to keep his own virgin, he will do well."*

In contrast to the previous verse, the man improperly courting his virgin, Paul speaks here about the man "who has stood firm in his heart." The Greek verb translated "has stood" (εστηκεν) is in the perfect tense, and it describes a man *who has and continues* to be *staid, set,* and *fixed,* as one who is firm in his heart. The Greek word rendered "firm" (εδραιος) basically refers to *one who is seated,* hence*, settled, steadfast,* and *constant*. Amplifying the thought presented here, the man who has and continues to stand fixed, firm, and steadfast in his heart, keeping his virgin, does well. The Greek noun translated "heart" (καρδια), as used here, obviously speaks of the *mind,* the *intellect*, the sphere in which decisions are made (cf. Rom. 1:21; 8:27; 2 Cor. 9:7).

The man who has been and is staid in a settled mind is one "not having necessity" of marriage. The present participle used here implies that while he continues having this unflinching mindset he will have *no need,* i.e., *nothing to constrain and compel* him to get married. Again we emphasize, we must keep in mind that at this time, the present distress, Paul is primarily looking at marriage as a safety net to catch those on the verge of falling into fornication (v. 2).

Paul says that this man "has authority concerning his own will." The Greek word rendered "authority" (εξουσιαν) means that he has the *right of control, power,* and *rule over* his own will. The Greek preposition rendered "concerning" conveys the idea of *about, respecting,* or *pertaining* his own will. The Greek phrase translated "his own will" (του ιδιου θελληματος) refers to *his own peculiar* will, *his idiosyncratic* will, or that *which-belongs-to-him* will. The Greek noun rendered "will" (θελληματος), as used here, has the thought of *resolve, purpose,* and *design.* Paul is obviously teaching here that the believer has the authority, power, and right to control what he wills, resolves, and purposes (cf. 16:12). Believers, who are alive in Christ, have both the authority and responsibility, in conjunction with the Holy Spirit, to conform their wills to the Word of God for the Church (cf. Rom. 12:2; Col. 3:16).

Paul continues to give us more information about this man, he is one who "has determined this in his own heart, to keep his own virgin." The Greek verb translated "has determined" (κεκρικεν) is in the perfect tense and active voice, which indicates

that this man who is a believer has himself "determined" (κεκρικεν), *judged* on the basis of evidence, *made up his mind,* and *decided* in his own heart to keep his virgin. What we said above about the noun "heart" (καρδια,) being used synonymously with our English word mind applies here. This man has judged, decided, and made the decision *in his own mind* "to keep" (τηρειν) his virgin.

The Greek infinitive, present tense, rendered "keep" (τηρειν) basically means to continuously *watch, protectively watch over, guard,* and *preserve.* Without going beyond Paul's intended meaning in this context, we need to adhere to the basic meaning that this man has determined to keep, guard, and protect his virgin as a lady friend. Since the time has been shortened (v. 29), the coming of the Lord seemed very near, the thought may be that he was to keep his virgin until the Lord appeared. Whatever the exact details, Paul fully approves of this man's determined mindset to keep his virgin, and declares that *he does well.*

*38. "So then also the one marrying his own virgin does well, and the one not marrying will do better."*

The first half of this verse gives us a positive summary of verse 36. In that verse Paul ordered the super-passionate man to marry his virgin, which he says is not to commit a sin, and in this verse he says that the one who follows this course "does well" (καλως ποιει), i.e., *acts rightly, correctly,* and *properly*. For him to have allowed his strong sexual drive to result in fornication would have been evil (κακος), but for him to fittingly express it within the confine of marriage is to *do well, act rightly*.

The second half of this verse gives us a positive summary of verse 37. In that verse we have a record of a man who has determined in his mind to keep his virgin in a chaste single state, as a result of which Paul says that "he will do well" (καλως ποιησει), the future tense, which in this context means the same as *he does well*. In other words, Paul uses the same phrase with reference to both the man who keeps his virgin and the one who marries his virgin - *both men do well*. This suggests that the man not marrying has only a slightly *preferred position* over the man who marries, even though Paul says that the former "will do better" (κρεισσον ποιησει), *superior,* or *more than well*. Furthermore, we must remember that Paul makes this distinction, as slight as it may be, in the light of the present distress and shortened days prevailing at the time he was writing. This is definitely not to be interpreted as giving the unmarried a permanent preference over the married in this Church age.

*39."A wife has been bound for as long a time as her husband lives; but if the husband is dead, she is free to be married to whom she desires, only in the Lord."*

The Majority Text adds the noun "law" (νομω) to the forepart of this verse. We translate it, "A wife has been bound by the law for as long a time as her husband lives." In view of what Paul says in Romans 7:3, he undoubtedly had the Mosaic Law in mind when he wrote this verse, and whether or not the noun Law (νομω) appears in the original text, it is certainly implied. Furthermore, granting that this is a summation of truth from the Mosaic Law, we also have to grant that in this context

Paul applies the same truth to the Church. In other words, it is a universal marital principle applicable to both the Mosaic Law and Church administrations.

Now let us examine the statement, "A wife has been bound for as long a time as her husband lives." The Greek verb translated "has been bound" (δεδεται) is in the perfect tense and passive voice and means that she *has been tied, fastened,* and *confined* to her husband. This is a very general statement, and as it is applied to the Church, it is *qualified* by the spiritual status of the woman's husband (vv. 10-11). If the husband is an unbeliever and separates from his believing wife, *she has not been bound, she has not been subjected to bondage,* or *she has not been enslaved* (cf. v. 15). Also, in verse 27, without giving any details, Paul speaks about the believer who has been loosed from a wife as he urges them to maintain the status quo.

The phrase "for as long a time as" (εφ' οσον χρονον) may also be rendered *on the basis of as long a time* as her husband lives. In the latter case the meaning is - a wife has been bound *on the basis of the fact* that her husband is living. This rendering adheres closely to the basic meaning of the Greek preposition "επι."

The clause translated "but if the husband is dead" (εαν δε κοιμηθη ο ανηρ) may also be rendered but if the husband *may fall asleep in death* or *should he sleep in death*, then the wife is free. On the basis of her husband's death she is "free" (ελευθερα), *unfettered,* and *at liberty* to marry whomever she "desires" (Θελει), *wishes,* or *wants* to marry. Paul adds one qualification to this statement, the person she marries must be "in the Lord," i.e., he must know the Lord, be a true believer. This is a very *general statement*, the minimum requirement is stipulated, for it would not have been propitious for Paul to get involved in the ramifications of cross-cultural marriages.

Having exegeted the truth which is set forth in this verse, there remain unanswered questions due to its brevity. What if a woman's husband was an unbeliever and separated from her, then married another woman, would she still be bound to him until he died? What if a believer was deceived in his/her courtship, and learned after marriage that his/her spouse was an empty professor, who in turn departed from the marriage, would the believer still be bound by a civil contract based on deception and fraud? We raise these questions to point out that this verse is *very brief and general* and must be understood in the light of the total truth in this chapter.

*40."But she is happier if she remains so (single), according to my opinion, and I think that I also have the Spirit of God."*

As Paul opens this chapter he encourages men not to touch women (v. 1), and as he closes it he feels that women, particularly widows, will be happier if they remain single. The reason for this negative advice regarding marriage is, of course, the present distress and the terrible conditions associated with it (vv. 26-31). Furthermore, in the light of the times, Paul wanted them to be as free as possible to mature spiritually and to serve the Lord (vv. 32-35).

Now let us look at Paul's statement pertaining to the widow who is maritally free - as he sees it "she is happier if she remains so." The Greek word translated "happier" (μαπαριωτερα) is a comparative form and may well be rendered *more blessed*. Paul uses it to describe the *felicitous state* of those whose sins have been forgiven (Rom. 4:7-8). As a believer, this widow already knows the happiness of forgiven sins, but if she remains single she will be even *more happy* than if she remarried, i.e., considering the conditions at that time.

The Greek phrase translated "if she remains so" (εαν ουτως μεινη) means that *if she may remain or continue thus, in the same way,* or *in the same manner* she is as a widow. Paul does not dogmatically assert that if the widow remains single she will be happier, but according to his "opinion" (γνωμην), *evaluation of the situation,* or *as he sees it* from his vantage point she will enjoy greater felicity. Again, not being dogmatic, he says, "I think that I also have the Spirit of God." The Greek verb rendered "I think" (δοκω) means *I consider, I presume,* and *as I understand* myself, my opinion is not of human origin but has been formulated by the Holy Spirit.

The statement, "I think that I also have the Spirit of God," must not be wrested out of its immediate context. In substantiating the opinion he has given, he is merely affirming that he considers the *Spirit of God has impressed it on his mind* (1 Cor. 2:10, 13). As one who endeavored to live and walk by the Spirit (Gal. 5:25), and whose mind was saturated by the things of the Spirit (Eph. 5:18), Paul did not draw a distinct line of demarcation between what he wrote under the direct inspiration of the Spirit and the control of the Spirit (cf. v. 25). It is important to keep this *minimal distinction* in mind as we bathe our minds in the truth of this chapter.

# *Ephesians 5:22-33*

Having thoroughly exegeted First Corinthians 7:1-40, now let us turn our attention to a brief exegesis of Ephesians 5:22-33, an important portion dealing with the subject of marriage. As we approach this fifth chapter let us keep in mind that Paul is *using the relation between Christ and His Church to depict* what the relation should be between a husband and his wife. At the time this epistle was written the concept of Christ and His Church was sufficiently understood so that Paul could use it as an illustration, moving from it, the known, to the unknown, a Christian husband-wife relation. As in First Corinthians, our primary purpose will be to tersely exegete this portion of Scripture and let you draw your own conclusions. Our job is exegetical, to as accurately as possible lead and draw out the truth, not to tell you what to believe, for that is between the Word/Spirit and you.

*22. "Wives be subject to your own husbands, as to the Lord,"*

This is a translation of the Greek in the Majority Text. Since the verb translated "be subject" (υποτασσεσθε) is not in the United Bible Societies' Text, the same thought being carried over from the participle in verse 21, we prefer the flow of thought in the Majority Text in this case. This Greek verb rendered "be subject" (υποτασσεσθε) consists of the preposition "υπο" prefixed to the verb "τασσω," and it literally means *to arrange, set,* or *bring under*. The present tense, imperative mode, and middle voice mean that Paul is commanding wives to arrange themselves under their husbands at all times. This same word, in participle form, is used in the preceding verse to describe how *all believers* are to be arranged under or subject to one another.

*23."because the husband is head of the wife as also Christ is head of the church, he himself being the Saviour of the body."*

The Greek conjunction "οτι," translated "because," states the reason why wives are to be subject to their own husbands, namely, *because* or *on account of* the fact that the husband is head of the wife. This is not a position which husbands have usurped, but it is the position given to them by the Lord. As head of the wife the husband has the responsibility of *caring for, providing for,* and *protecting* his wife (1 Tim. 5:8). Since no two minds are perfectly synchronized in the world in which we live, maximum cooperation, togetherness, and harmony is attained when there is both assumption and recognition of leadership in a marriage.

The adverb "as" (ως) indicates that *according as* or *like as* Christ is head of the Church the husband is head of the wife. Even as there is no room for disputing Christ's headship over the Church (1 Cor.11:3; Eph.1:22; 4:15; Col. 1:18; 2:19); likewise, there is no room for disputing the husband's headship over his wife (1 Cor. 11: 3; Col. 3:18; Titus 2:5).

Having said that Christ is head of the Church, Paul adds, "he himself being the Saviour of the body." The word "Saviour" (σωτηρ) means one who is a *rescuer, deliverer,* and *preserver*. As Christ is the spiritual Saviour of the Body, the Church, likewise, the husband is the physical deliverer and preserver of his wife's well-being. This includes her mental, emotional, and physical health.

*24. "But as the church is subject to Christ, so also the wives to their husbands in everything."*

The present time, when the Church is subject to Christ, is called "the dispensation of the grace of God" (Eph. 3:2). God is not governing his people by the principle of grace. Members of the Body of Christ are *not forced* to be subject to Him, but as those who have been made righteous in Christ they are *encouraged* and *urged* to be subject to Him in accordance with the Word (Rom. 12:1; Eph. 4:1; Heb. 10:25).

Even as the Church is subject to Christ in a voluntary grace relation; in the same way wives are to voluntarily in-grace be subject to their husbands. Just as Christ graciously pleads with us to be subject to Him, and we voluntarily arrange ourselves under Him in the Holy Spirit, in the same manner wives are to listen to His gracious pleading to *voluntarily arrange themselves under* their husbands, which is inseparable from their submission to Him as Head of the Body. Observe, wives are to submit to their husbands "in everything" (εν παντι). This literally means that *in every single thing* wives are to arrange themselves under their husbands. This is a very terse statement, it mentions no exceptions, and obviously assumes that the husbands are arranged under Christ; otherwise, it could lead to a conflict between wives submitting to Christ, the Head of the Body, and to their own husbands, the heads of each family (Col. 1:10, 18).

*25. "Husbands, love your wives, even as also Christ loved the church and gave himself up for it."*

In the previous verses Paul has been addressing the wives, exhorting them to align themselves under their husbands, whereas in this verse he begins addressing the husbands. He commands them (imperative mode) to love "the wives" (τας γυναικας), i.e., the husbands are to love their own wives. The Greek verb translated "love" (αγαπατε) means that husbands are to *be devoted to, be affectionate toward,* and to *be kindly concerned* for their wives. This is the most common verb used in the New Testament to express love, both Divine and human, and its presence is seen in the attitudes and actions it produces, i.e., by its fruits (1 Cor. 13:47).

The pattern for this love is the manner in which "Christ loved the church and gave himself for it." First, observe on the basis of the meaning of this verb that Christ has expressed His devotion, affection, and concern for those who constitute His Church (Eph. 2:47). Second, note the fact that Christ "gave himself up" (εαυτον παρεδωκεν), *gave Himself over,* and *delivered Himself up* on Calvary "for it" (υπερ αυτες), *on behalf of her*, the Church, verifies His love for it. In the annals of history this is the supreme example of love (Rom. 5:6-8; 1 John 4:9-10). To love our wives as Christ loved the Church means that we will have to be *willing to die for them*, on behalf of them, as circumstances may demand.

*26. "that he might sanctify it having cleansed with the washing of water with the word,"*

Even though verses 26-27, pertain exclusively to the Church, we will briefly consider the truth in them, for Paul's application in verse 28, rests upon what precedes it. The conjunction "ινα" with the subjunctive mode pinpoints the purpose for which Christ gave Himself, namely, in order that he might "sanctify" (αγιαση), *set apart,* and *make the Church holy*. The aorist participle translated "having cleansed it" (καθαρισας) refers to action prior to that of the leading verb. This means that Christ cleansed the Church with the washing of water by the Word *before He sanctified it*; in fact, as a result of having its filth of sin washed away, it was set apart as holy. Don't forget, this figurative language used here goes back to the Cross, He gave Himself, for its cleansing efficacy.

*27. "that he might present to himself the glorious church, not having spot or wrinkle or any such thing, but that it might be holy and without blemish."*

This verse also begins with "ινα" with the subjunctive mode expressing Christ's *purpose* to present to Himself the glorious Church. Again we observe, the prerequisite to having a glorious Church to present to Himself was the fact that *He gave Himself on Calvary*; in other words, the purpose of Calvary was the glorious Church. Paul describes this Church as being void of "spot" (σπιλον), *stain, a soil,* and *a blot*, or even a "wrinkle" (ρυτιδα) or *slight flaw*, or any defects along these lines. Negatively speaking, the Church was to have no defects, whereas positively speaking, it was to be "holy" (αγια). This indicates that the status of the Church is *separated from that which is common*, hence, *separated unto Christ, righteous,* and *pure*. As a holy Church, it is "without blemish" (αμωμος), *free of blame, fault,* or *disgrace.*

*28. "So husbands ought also to love their own wives as their own bodies, the one loving his own wife loves himself,"*

The Greek adverb translated "so" (ουτως) means that *in the same way or manner* as Christ loved the Church and gave Himself for it, that He might sanctify it, make it glorious, and holy, husbands are to love their own wives "as their own bodies." In following through the example of Christ's love for the Church, which is His Body, the husbands are to love their wives "as" (ως), *like as, as they were* their own bodies. There appears to be two possible ways to interpret this statement: 1) Paul is speaking about the need for husbands to love their wives as they love their own *personal bodies;* 2) Paul is telling them to love their wives as those *who are or represent their own bodies,* i.e., even as the Church is Christ's Body the wives are the bodies of the husbands (cf. 1 Cor. 7:4). We feel that both of these interpretations are in accordance with what Paul teaches, but that the latter seems to flow better in this context. "The one loving his own wife loves himself," for his wife is *a part of himself,* they are one flesh (cf. v. 3 1).

*29. "for no one ever hated his own flesh, but nourishes and cherishes it, even as also Christ the church."*

Again we raise the question, what does Paul mean by the phrase "his own flesh"? Is he referring to his own personal flesh-body or is he referring to the joint-flesh-body of him and his wife? The evidence suggests that the latter is true, with primary emphasis on the wife-part-of-his-flesh. True, the statement that "no one ever hated his own flesh" basically refers to his personal flesh, which it would be foreign to hate, but the context broadens this to *include his wife.* Instead of one hating his flesh, the very opposite is true, he "nourishes" (εκτρεφει), *meticulously feeds,* and *supports it with adequate nutrition* and "cherishes" (θαλπει), *warms, fosters,* and *gives it the needed affection*.

The statement, "even as also Christ the church" is very significant in giving us insight into Paul's intended meaning in these verses. This conveys the idea that *in the same way and manner* Christ nourishes and cherishes the Church, which is an *objective apart-from-self* feeding and caring, the husbands are also to objectively give nutrition and affection to their wives-part-of-their-flesh. Here we have the universal principle of love of self-flesh expanded to include love of wife-flesh, conceived as a single whole, and used as an ingredient in the depicting of Christ's care for His Church, which in turn is an example of what a husband's relation should be to his wife.

*30. "because we are members of his body."*

The Majority Text adds to this verse the words "out of his flesh and out of his bones." The obvious reference of the phrase "his body" (σωματος αυτος) is to His spiritual Body, the Church, and the added statement pertaining to His flesh and bones seems to confuse the true meaning of the context. What Paul is saying here is that "because we are members of his body" He provides for our spiritual nutrition and need for Him to care about us. Even as Christ feeds and cares for the members of His Body, not Himself, likewise, husbands are to feed and care for the wives-part-of-their-flesh.

*31. “For this cause a man shall .leave his father and mother and shall be joined to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh."*

This quotation from Genesis 2:24, clarifies the meaning of the phrase, "his own flesh," in verse 29. Since the husband and wife are *one flesh*, they are flesh of one another, and the wife is logically spoken of as being the flesh of her husband. The husband's concern should involve his *total flesh,* which includes both that of his wife and himself. What we said above was in the light of this entire context, and particularly the fact that "the two shall become one flesh," which substantiates the interpretation that the husband is to nurture and cherish his wife, a part of his flesh.

*32. "This mystery is great, but I speak regarding Christ and the church."*

The antecedent of this statement is not verse 31, but verse 30, and all that preceded it pertaining to Christ and His relation to the Church. The Truth which Paul has presented in verses 23-30, using Christ and His Church as an example of the marital relationship, is Truth which was not previously revealed (3:5). Paul commonly refers to this Truth as "the mystery" (το μυστηριον), that which had

previously been hidden and kept secret, but having been revealed it constitutes *all the Truth pertaining to Christ and His Church* (3:3).

As one lives with Paul in his epistles, gradual identification with him takes place - one begins to share his excitement in the new Truth of the Mystery. In the verse before us Paul defines this Mystery as being "great" (μεγα), an adjective which may mean *large, comprehensive,* and *magnificent.* In this particular verse it appears that the primary emphasis is on the magnificent Mystery Truth which describes Christ's *loving, nurturing,* and *caring* relationship with His Church.

*33. "Nevertheless also you yourselves let each one love his own wife even as himself, and the wife that she might respect the husband."*

In the previous verse Paul was dealing with *the Truth involved in his example*, whereas in this verse he is dealing with the practical application of this Truth, the Mystery, to the marital relation. The adverb translated "nevertheless" may also be rendered *moreover, besides,* or *beyond* what has been said. The Greek words translated "you yourselves" (υμεις οι) are in the plural and seems to be *emphasizing* that what Paul is saying applies directly to them all as members of the Body of Christ. From the plural he drops down to a singular, ordering each individual husband (καθ' ενα εκαστος) to love his own (εαυτου) wife in the same manner as he loves himself. This is a recapitulation of what he said in verses 28-29. As a part of his own flesh he will love his wife as himself, for they have the status of one flesh.

We observe that Paul emphasizes the need for husbands *to love* their own wives (vv. 26, 28; Col. 3:19). If this emphasis was not necessary, if Christian husbands were loving their wives as they should, it would not have been necessary for him to command them to do so. The implication is that even Christian husbands don't just naturally love thier wives as they ought to, it is not an area in which they can depend upon their feelings, but they need to be disciplined by the Holy Spirit to love their wives according to the knowledge of the Word (1 Peter 3:7). There is a vast difference between *erotic love*, which has as its object the gratification of the flesh, and the *agape love* of the Spirit, of which the object is both the physical and spiritual well-being of the person loved (1 Cor. 13:47; Gal. 5:22).

Why doesn't Paul, in the same manner, command wives to love their husbands? Was it because they just naturally loved their husbands and had no problems in this area? A cursory glance at historical and contemporary marital problems answers this question with a *resounding no!* Let us look at some more feasible reasons: 1) because *the husband* is *head* of the wife Paul directs this mutually applicable command to him; 2) because Paul has one *major command* for the wife, *submission* (respect), and for the husband, *love*, he lets the latter carry over by implication; and 3) because Paul has *already commanded all believers* to hold up one another in love, which includes the wife sustaining her husband in love (4:2; 5:2; Titus 2:45; Philemon 1:9).

Paul uses the imperative mode to command each husband to love his wife. He uses the subjunctive mode to express his desire for each wife - that her *purpose* may be to respect her husband. The Greek verb translated "respect" (φοβηται) conveys the idea of *to fear, to be afraid of*, hence, as used here, *fear resulting from unsubmission, to reverentially arrange herself under,* or *to show respect and deference to her*

*husband* (his God-given role). This is the only time Paul uses either the verb or noun form of this word regarding the relation of a wife to her husband. He does, however, use it to characterize the respectful relations which should exist between all believers (v. 21; 2 Cor. 7:15; Phil. 2:12).

Summarizing, according to First Corinthians chapter 7, at that point in time Paul looked at marriage as a *second best,* a safety net, enabling those with strong passions and lacking self-control to avoid the dread sin of fornication. In this fifth chapter of Ephesians, verses 22-33, at the time Paul writes this encyclical epistle he speaks *very positively* about marriage. He uses the highest imaginable example, Christ and His Church, to exemplify the ideal relationship between a husband and his wife. The combined truth of both of these epistles governs marriage in this Church age. According to the principle of progressive revelation, where there is an apparent difference of attitude toward the desirability of marriage, the latest revelation of truth should be followed, that recorded in Ephesians.

# *Colossians 3:18-19*

Having considered what Paul has to say on the subject of marriage in First Corinthians 7:1-40, and in Ephesians 5:22-33, the two major portions in his epistles dealing with this subject, now let us turn our attention to some random passages in Colossians, First Timothy, and Titus. Again we emphasize, our primary purpose is *to bring out the literal intended meaning* of each of these passages, and it is your job to draw your own conclusions through Spirit-given insight into His Word for this Church age. We are fully aware that many have taken it upon themselves to dictate what you should believe on this subject, which needs to be counterbalanced by what the Apostle Paul has to say, that your thinking may be governed by Divine revelation (Gal. 1:12), rather than the traditions of men.

*3:18 "Wives, be subject to your husbands, as is fitting in the Lord."*

This verse is addressed to believing wives. The use of the present tense, imperative mode, and middle voice means that Paul is commanding them themselves to continuously *be arranged under* and *submissive* to their husbands. The Greek verb translated "fitting" ( ανηκεν) is in the perfect tense and means *as has been and continues to be fitting, come up to, proper, appropriate,* and *becoming.* As used in Philemon 8, in participle form, it may be rendered as that which one ought to do or which is *right* to do. The perfect tense indicates that God's standard, that which is proper and right, has been and continues to be that which is fitting and appropriate in the Lord. In other words, the wife's under-arrangement to her husband is ordained by the Lord.

*3:19 "Husbands, love the wives and do not be bitter against them."*

This verse is addressed to believing husbands who needed to know what goes and what doesn't go in a Christian marriage. Positively, husbands are commanded to *continuously love the wives*. The translation "the wives" (τας γυναικας) is exactly what is in the Greek text, without the reflexive pronoun "αυτων" in the genitive case. Lest some unscrupulous interpreter, under the guise of being literal, may try to make this say that husbands are to mutually love the wives of one another, we hasten to add that the meaning of the reflexive pronoun in the genitive case is *frequently implied*, in which case Paul is commanding the husbands to "love your wives" (cf. 1 Cor. 7:3; Eph. 5:2425; 1 Tim. 3:12). Keep in mind that we use the phrase *literal meaning* synonymously with the *intended meaning*, which is inseparable from the context. This means that without any qualifications husbands are *ordered to love their own wives.*

Negatively, the husbands are not to allow themselves to become "bitter" (πικραινεσθε), *acrid, sharp,* and *harsh* toward their wives. The fact that this verb is in the present tense, imperative mode, and passive voice reveals that the husbands are commanded not to ever permit anyone (wives included) to make

them bitter and harsh toward their wives. This is the only time Paul uses this verb, and the only time it is used in the New Testament to refer to an acrimonious attitude.

# *First Timothy 2:11-12; 3:2, 12; 5:14*

*2:11-12 "Let a wife learn in quietness in all subjection. But I do not suffer a woman to teach, neither to have authority over a husband, but to be in quietness."*

The main thrust of these verses pertains to how a wife is to relate to her husband in a local assembly. It is not our purpose to exegete what her decorum should be in the assembly, such as she is to be quiet and not teach, except as it involves her relation to her husband. First, in relation to her husband she is to be "in all subjection" (εν παση υποταγη). As previously observed, this means that she is to be *arranged under and to be submissive* to her husband. The Greek phrase translated "in all" (εν παση) suggests that she is to be under her husband in the sphere of *every thing*. Since this principle has already been observed in several earlier passages considered, we will not dwell on it here (Eph. 5:24).

Second, particularly in relation to her husband, a wife is not "to have authority" (αυθεντειν), *not to exercise her own authority, to be autocratic*, or to dominate her husband. Granted, the Greek word for "wife" (γυνη) and for "husband" (ανδρος) may also be translated woman and man. We believe this context has in the background faulty relations between wives and husbands in the local assembly, and in view of this Paul admonishes wives *to be subordinate* to their husband's and *not to dominate* them. Instead of wives loquaciously overriding their husbands in public meetings, Paul emphasizes, but (αλλα) they are to be *quiet, silent,* and *not making noise.*

*3:2 "Therefore it is necessary for the overseer to be without reproach, the husband of one wife, temperate, sound-minded, orderly, hospitable, able to teach,"*

There is one phrase in this verse which is pertinent to our subject, namely, the overseer must be "the husband of one wife" (μιας γυναικος ανδρα). This means that he must be a monogamous person, i.e., not have more than one wife simultaneously. In contrast to being a polygamist, something which was relatively common for those who could afford it at that time, *he must be* a monogamist (Eph. 5:31-33; 1 Tim. 3:12; Titus 1:6). There is no justification for interpreting this to mean *married only one time*. Such a view is clearly contrary to the plain teaching of the Scriptures (Rom. 7:2-3; 1 Cor. 7:15, 39).

*3:12 "Let deacons be the husbands of one wife, ruling their children and their own houses well;"*

Only the first half of this verse is pertinent to our subject - "Let deacons be the husbands of one wife." In the light of verse 2, Paul is obviously affirming that *each deacon* is to be the husband of *only one wife*. Paul has a single point that he is trying to get across here - deacons are to have only *one wife at a time*. He says nothing about

how many times deacons may have been married, for this has nothing to do with the issue he is addressing. Furthermore, this must not be interpreted to mean that a deacon (διακονος) must be married, for the same title is applied to both Paul and Timothy who were single (cf. Eph. 3:7; 1 Thess. 3:2; 1 Cor. 7:7).

For a more complete picture of what Paul has to say about the issue of remarriage, let us consider one of his final statements on the subject in First Timothy.

*5:14 "Therefore I desire younger women to marry, to bear children, to rule households, not to give one occasion to the adversary as a cause for reviling."*

The preceding verses (11-13) make it clear that the "younger women" are *younger widows* (νεωτερας ... χηρας). In view of the disgraceful lives these younger widows were prone to live, Paul "desires" (βουλομαι), *wishes, wills,* and *wants* them to remarry, i.e., this is his plan and purpose for them. Within the bonds of marriage there is both an opportunity to satisfy the strong natural craving of the flesh and the responsibilities which consume one's time, hence, deterring them from trouble.

# *Titus 1:6; 2:4-5*

*1:6 "if anyone is uníndictable, the husband of one wife, having faithful children, not accused of riot or rebellion."*

Here Paul is stipulating the qualifications of an elder. The phrase which pertains to our subject is that he is to be "the husband of one wife." In all three passages which we have cited, regarding the *overseer* (1 Tim. 3:2), the *deacons* (1 Tim. 3:12), and here the elders, the phrase "of one wife" (μιας γυναικος) is in the genitive case. The most basic meaning of the genitive case is *possession*, i.e., each of them are husbands who *belong to, are owned by,* and *the possession of one wife* at the time Paul is writing to them. It is conceivable that in the past some of them may have belonged to more than one wife, they may have been the husbands of two or more wives, but as those who are now believers, interested in serving as an overseer, deacon, or elder, they are not eligible unless they are down to the *limit of one wife.* The Lord is not interested in how good people are in their sinful flesh before they are saved. His interest in their lifestyle begins *after they are saved* and endued with the cleansing power of the Holy Spirit (cf. Rom. 8:3-5).

*2:4-5 "that they may make young women sound-minded to love their husbands, love their children, sensible, pure, home workers, good submissive to their own husbands, that the word of God may not be blasphemed."*

The older women were to teach the young women to be sound minded in several different areas, two of which pertain to our subject, they were "to love their husbands" and to be "submissive to their husbands." The Greek word translated "to love their husbands" (φιλανδρους) is derived from "φιλος" and "ανηρ" and literally means *one who loves her husband, a husband-lover,* or *one who shows affection toward her husband.* This exhortation needs to be balanced with what we said under Ephesians 5:33, substantiating the fact that as members of the Body of Christ it was implied that wives would love their own husbands. Since the words "αγαπη" and "φιλος" are often used almost synonymously, there is no justification for trying to minutely differentiate between the husband and wife love mentioned here.

Lastly, the young women were to be taught to be "submissive to their own husbands." The Greek participle translated "submissive" (υποτασσομενας) is in the present tense and middle voice, which means that these young wives are to *continuously submit themselves*, arrange themselves, under their husbands. Over and over again this same word, in either the verb or participle form, has been used to stress how important it is for wives to be arranged under their husbands. As those who have the solemn responsibility of exegeting what the Greek New Testament says on this subject, it is not for us to question why God has ordained this order, but *to lead out the literal-intended-meaning,* this is *what God says, it is the relation which He has ordained.*

# *Conclusion*

In dealing with the issue of marriage, separation, and possible remarriage, we must guard against reading into the Scriptures preconceived traditional views. For some strange reason, beyond our comprehension, divorce has been singled out and given a rating nigh unto the unpardonable sin. Generally speaking, circumstances surrounding the divorce aren't taken into consideration, i.e., was the person divorced prior to being saved, as a result of an unsaved spouse separating from the marriage, or because the marriage contract was based upon the deception and fraud of a pseudo-believer?

We are living in days when it is often very difficult to determine whether the person one marries is a genuine believer. In the final analysis the test is *obedience* to the Word of God, continuing unmovable in the faith (Col. 1:23). If either the husband or wife openly refuses to obey God's directives for them in the marriage, such as the husband refusing to love and support his wife (1 Tim. 5:8) and the wife refusing to respect and be submissive to her husband, we have reason to suspect that such disregard for the Word of God indicates the person is still in Satan's family (2 Cor. 6:14). If this unbeliever separates him/herself from the marriage obligations, and seeks satisfaction outside of the marriage, we interpret this as *departing* (χωριζεται) from the marriage and leaving the believing spouse as one who has not been bound (1 Cor. 7:15).

It appears to us that many, in dealing with the subject of marriage and separation, have take the position of *legalists* (nomians) instead of the position of *gracists* (charians). The law is severe - it demands its pound. Grace *forgives* – it erases the past and begins a new life. In keeping with the gracious tenor of His ministry, Jesus said to the woman taken in adultery, "Neither do I condemn you; go your way; and *from now* (απο του νυν) sin no more (John 8:11). The past - forgiven - Jesus' concern was that she live *a new life*. Likewise, Saul of Tarsus, an insolent sinner, given mercy - the past obliterated - he is now a new creature and chief тevelator of the Truth for the Church (1 Tim. 1:12-16; Eph. 3:2-9). Why did God reach down and take a man so steeped in sin and with such animosity against Christ, when He could have taken a guileless Israelite like Nathaniel (John 1:47), unless He wanted to display the greatness of His grace in forgiving sinners? May our Lord help all of us to also forgive even as we have been forgiven (Col. 3:13).

Finally, as we have spoken about those who have had marital difficulties, separations, and divorces, and our need to graciously forgive them, we are *not implying* that all who are divorced have sinned. The very fact that one spouse becomes a believer may in itself aggravate the unbelieving spouse to get a divorce. In other words, faith in Jesus Christ and obedience to His Word may be the very thing that incites the unbeliever to separate from a marriage. May God give us empathetic compassion in such cases (Matt. 9:36).